VERBAL

Reading Comprehension

Improving Reading Speed & Accuracy

eBOOK

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Chapter 1 – Introduction to Reading Comprehension

1.1 Introduction

Verbal ability is a section found in nearly all competitive exams, especially in MBA entrances. It is an important testing parameter to judge a person's verbal aptitude, comprising of language skills, grammar and vocabulary. Within the Verbal section, reading comprehension is a key area. It generally presents a big hurdle for the candidates, as it tests the language skills of the candidates and topics are from diverse areas with varying levels of difficulty.

Working on Reading for main idea is important for you to crack questions on Reading Comprehension and also questions on Sentence Rearrangement and Critical Reasoning.

This book will equip you on basics of how to read, where to read from and other tips to improve your comprehension. It will prepare you to handle questions on critical reasoning, summary based questions, sentence rearrangement along with reading comprehension.

Structure of Reading Comprehension

Usually, you are given passages with 3- 4 paragraphs and these passages could be short or long (200- 500 words). Occasionally, you see a poem given for reading comprehension. Each RC passage may have approximately 3- 5 questions. Questions would be followed by 4 or 5 options. Content wise the passages would be from diverse fields such as social science, natural science, economics, politics, technology etc. You are not expected to have any prior knowledge of the various topics. However, having some familiarity with various topics enhance your comprehension.

If the test is on the computer, a passage appears on the left hand side of the screen and a related question appears on the right hand side of the screen. If the passage is longer than the screen, there will be a scroll bar that will allow you to scroll up and down the text.

Note: Please note that the number of passages, questions and weightage vary from exam to exam and also each year on year.

1.2 Relevance in entrance tests

About one-third of the questions in the verbal section of CAT, XAT, and NMAT etc. would be on Reading Comprehension. It is the main area of the verbal section. Reading Comprehension is probably the only thing you should care about in Verbal for CAT in order to score a 99%ile. Same is the case for IIFT, XAT and NMAT, where RCs help boost your scores.

Let's look at the trend of last three years tests pattern.

Year	Questions	CAT	IIFT	NMAT	SNAP	XAT
2014	Total questions in Verbal section	34	37	32	40	28
	No. of Questions in RC	16	17	8	9	15
	No. of Passages	4	4	2	2	5
2015	Total questions in Verbal section	34	36	32	40	28
	No. of Questions in RC	24	16	8	5	15- 18
	No. of Passages	5	4	2	1	6

2016	Total questions in Verbal section	34	36	32	40	26
	No. of Questions in RC	24	16	8	11	12- 14
	No. of Passages	5	4	2	2	4

We also see that in tests like CAT, there are questions on summarise the paragraph, what is the inference- which are based on information given in one paragraph.

Hence mastering your reading skills will equip you to handle these summary and inference based question too.

1.3 What is measured?

a. **Your ability to understand written English** - This does not mean you will be checked on your Grammar knowledge and the meaning of the words, but rather the overall understanding of the passage.

b. **Your ability to relate logical relationship between facts and concepts**-For example you may be asked to evaluate the relevance of certain supporting idea or example within a passage.

c. **Your ability to draw inferences**- It checks how well you can draw conclusions from the information given in the passage.

There are two myths about Reading Comprehension:

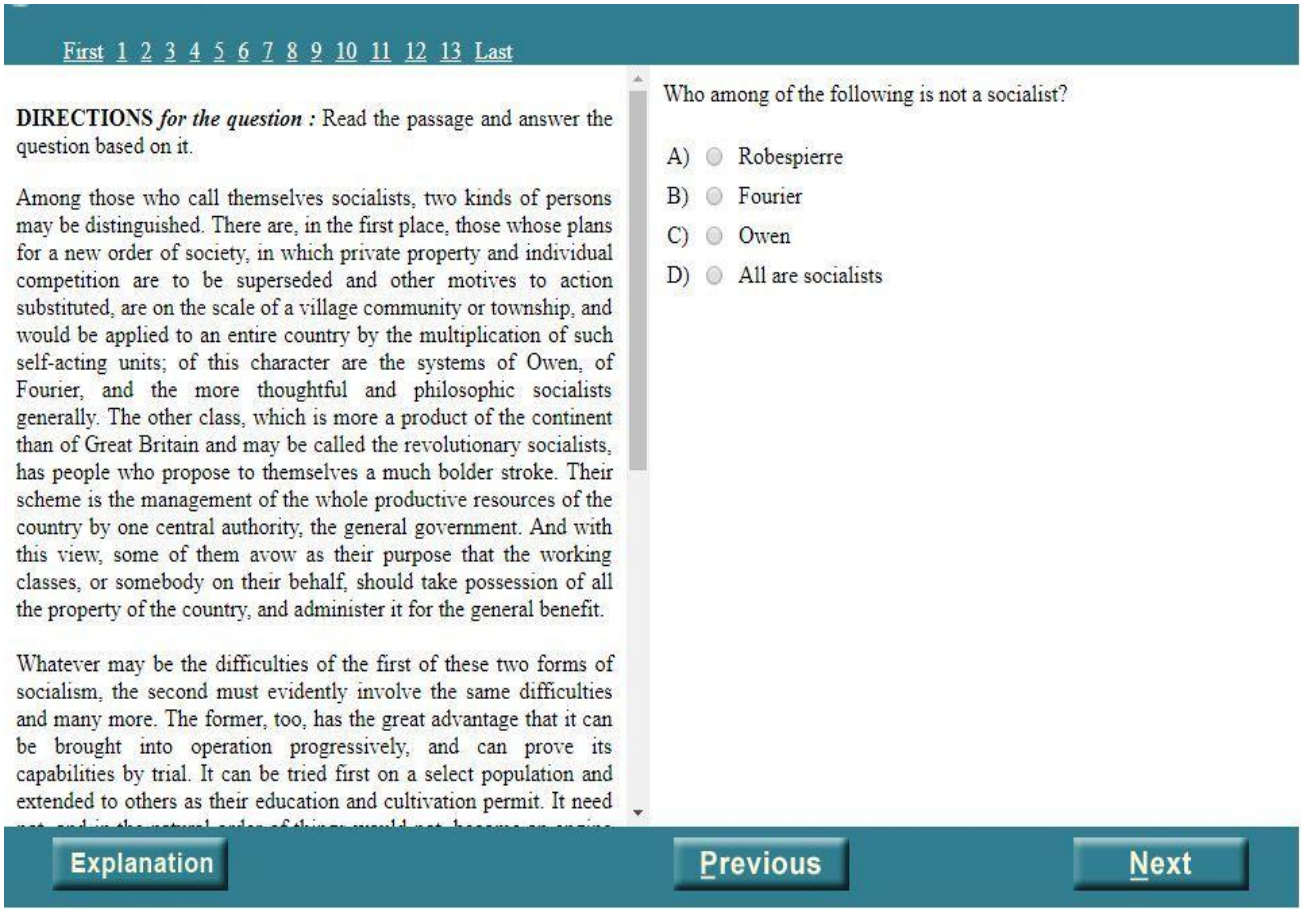
1. **The Reading comprehension is a test of speed reading**
   This is not true. Students who think this is a true try to read the passage a lightening pace and lose at comprehending the passage, eventually forced to re-read the passage.

2. **Reading Comprehension test your ability to memories minute details in the passage**.
   This is not true. Students who believe this make the mistake of making a note of minute details and too many unnecessary facts. This not only wastes your time but also prevents you from looking at the broader idea of the passage.

1.4 What skills are required?

- Regular reading habit
- Exposure to diverse topics
- Remaining focussed while reading
- Engaging with the passage
- Comprehension skills
- Comfortable reading speed so as not to lose focus of comprehension

1.5 Sample RC passage



First 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 Last

DIRECTIONS ***for the question :*** Read the passage and answer the question based on it.

Among those who call themselves socialists, two kinds of persons may be distinguished. There are, in the first place, those whose plans for a new order of society, in which private property and individual competition are to be superseded and other motives to action substituted, are on the scale of a village community or township, and would be applied to an entire country by the multiplication of such self-acting units; of this character are the systems of Owen, of Fourier, and the more thoughtful and philosophic socialists generally. The other class, which is more a product of the continent than of Great Britain and may be called the revolutionary socialists, has people who propose to themselves a much bolder stroke. Their scheme is the management of the whole productive resources of the country by one central authority, the general government. And with this view, some of them avow as their purpose that the working classes, or somebody on their behalf, should take possession of all the property of the country, and administer it for the general benefit.

Whatever may be the difficulties of the first of these two forms of socialism, the second must evidently involve the same difficulties and many more. The former, too, has the great advantage that it can be brought into operation progressively, and can prove its capabilities by trial. It can be tried first on a select population and extended to others as their education and cultivation permit. It need

Who among of the following is not a socialist?

A) Robespierre
B) Fourier
C) Owen
D) All are socialists

Explanation Previous Next

1.6 How to use this book

- This book adopts a step by step approach to help you improve your reading skills
- You are requested to go through each chapter sequentially. Do not jump to the other chapter before understanding and imbibing the concepts mentioned in the previous chapter
- Practise simultaneously from the practise exercise given at the end of the chapters (wherever applicable)
- After reading the concepts and practising a particular topic from this book, you can use other practise exercises from our website or online learning programme

Note: This book contains very important concept of WHAT, WHY AND HOW to improve your reading speed and comprehension. However, you need to experiment and find out what works better for you and adopt that style.

The second part of this book will deal in detail the various question types and strategies to deal with each question type with practise exercises.

Chapter 2: Tips to overcome challenges faced while attempting RC

Reading comprehension is a critical section in CAT and other tests as it constitutes a major portion of the verbal ability area. The topics are from diverse field and also the difficulty level of the passage varies. Above all there is a constant pressure of time and accuracy to crack this section.

Test takers are anxious and want to give their best. It is important to maintain your calmness while preparing for the entrance tests .Do not be scared to attempt questions of Reading Comprehension. This section will discuss in general the common doubts raised while preparing for Reading Comprehension section and proposed suggestions of dealing with them.

Note: Each individual has his own style, speed, comprehension levels and accuracy, you need to analyse what works best for you. For this you need to practise. Give sufficient mock tests under simulated setting and analyse your performance. Then change your strategy to what suits or works the best for you.

2.1 Some of the challenges faced:

a. I get distracted while reading

Suggestion:
Practise reading every day. Set a target and maintain a disciplined routine for reading. First begin with whatever interests you. It could be newspaper articles, blogs etc. But get in the habit of reading every day. Slowly focus on comprehension while reading. Write the summary in 1- 2 lines after you read each paragraph. Keep a record of your reading style. Gradually move to diverse topics and read minimum 2- 3 RC passages every day.

Making notes, or summarising in the margin can be very helpful in creating a mind map of the structure – as you read along. Try it out and experience the benefits.

b. I get lost in the vocabulary and complex sentences

Suggestion:
When you solve RC passages in the exam make sure that vocabulary constraints do not come in the way of the comprehending the passage. Though it is likely that some of the words in the passage are unfamiliar to you, try to guess the meaning of those unfamiliar words from the context in which they are used.
Focus on the key idea/ main idea of each paragraph rather than focussing on individual words.

An efficient reader would focus on the parts of the passage that are clearly understood, and then make educated guesses about the parts that are too complex to immediately understand. Make sure that the passage is thus adequately understood.

c. I am comfortable reading only familiar topics

Suggestion:
First of all don't be scared of unfamiliar areas. You need to keep your reading habit consistent. Unfamiliar ideas or subject matter would not pose a big problem if you have consistent reading habit. Read diverse subjects, although it is not necessary to master every subject under the sun. Try to get the gist of the passage. Do not focus on speed on such topics to begin with. Your aim is to get familiarity on the diverse topics.

d. I go to previous lines again and again because I lose track of what I read

Suggestion:
Use the note make technique. Some people trace their way through the passage using their finger or a pencil. Using a pacer helps avoid regression, enhances your focus on the text, and your concentration. It slows you down slightly, but it ensures that no word or idea is missed. Experiment and see if it is worth it. If you find it a waste of time, do without it.

e. I understand only when I read aloud

Suggestion:
In the exam hall you can't read aloud.
Sub vocalisation i.e. reading aloud reduces your reading speed. Your brain can process much faster than what your tongue can speak. Consciously practise without reading aloud. Initially your speed or comprehension may not be great, but with practise and note making technique, it shall improve.

f. I understand only when I underline

Suggestion:
On the computer based test, you cannot underline. You can just move your pen/finger across the lines. Substitute underlining by writing the key idea in the margin or on the piece of paper.

g. I get confused while marking the answers

Suggestion:
First understand the type of question asked and the technique to answer those questions.
For example, a question may ask: *which of the following options makes the author's conclusion supportable?* Comprehension of this question would mean that you first define the author's conclusion in the passage. In this case, many of us tend to spend more time evaluating the options without understanding the conclusion or the main idea of the passage. We immediately move to options.

As a result, we are confused by the options. Whenever you are confused by the options, you need to check whether it is your inadequate comprehension of either the passage or the question that is creating the confusion.
Read: How to solve various question types in RC book 2

h. Should I read the questions first or the passage?

Suggestion:
In most of the exams like CAT, the questions are mostly inference based. These questions require your understanding of the passage. If you read the questions and option first, chances are you may get distracted from the main theme.
So, you can either read the entire passage and answer the questions referring back to the passage to ensure accuracy or
Skim through the entire passage. Skim through the questions Read the entire passage. Answer the questions
You need to practice and decide on your method.

i. Should I choose a passage to attempt?

Suggestion:
If the paper allows you sufficient choice among passages, choose the passages wisely. Skim through the entire passage as quickly as you can. Judge whether you would like to continue studying this passage. If so, short list it as a likely passage to attempt. Do the same with the other passages. Remember to work fast in this process. At the end you may have short listed a couple of passages or more that you would be comfortable reading. After that apply the methodology most comfortable to you and work with those passages.

The selection of passages is completely based on the comfort that you experience with the passage. If you find a particular passage easy, you will be able to attempt the questions based on that passage comfortably. But if you find that a passage is easy to read and understand, you will be able to work with even the most difficult question set on it. Hence choose the passages that you are most comfortable reading.

If the paper, however, does not offer you the freedom to choose, you must try to do your best even in an uncomfortable passage by making a habit of reading diverse topics.

j. How many questions should I attempt in RC?

Suggestion:

Your focus should be on improving the accuracy in RC. So attempt a limited number of questions and ensure accuracy .However, if your overall attempts are far below the target you have set, it is necessary to attempt questions to meet that target. At all times, in a competitive exam with negative marking, your attempt should be to maximise your marks not merely by attempting the maximum number of questions possible, but also by minimising the negative.

Analyse your performance during mock tests to decide the number of attempts to maximize your score. Since different individuals have different accuracy, the number of attempts and speed, you need to analyse on your individual performance and your goal.

Chapter 3 : Reading Comprehension Passage Types

Passages given in the Reading Comprehension sections are based on diverse field of studies or topic.

Because the Reading Comprehension section of the exam includes passages from several different content areas, you may be generally familiar with some of the material; however, no specific knowledge of the material is required.

All questions are to be answered on the basis of what is stated or implied in the reading material.
To answer the questions, you need not be an expert in any of the subjects mentioned earlier, but you need a general awareness of these topics.
The best way to build awareness is through consistent reading on diverse subjects.

3.1 Different Passage types

A. Social Science Passages

These passages would be from areas such as history, politics, and geography. These passages are enjoyable to read and are not too dense.
Generally, a lot of inferential questions are based on these passages, which check your reading ability as well as how closely you have followed the passage.

Sample Passage

For most Americans and Europeans, this should be the best time in all of **human history** to live. Survival — the very purpose of all life — is nearly guaranteed for large parts of the world, especially in the West.
This should allow **people a sense of security** and contentment. If life is no longer, as Thomas Hobbes famously wrote, "nasty, brutish, and short," then should it not be pleasant, dignified, and long? To know that tomorrow is nearly guaranteed, along with thousands of additional tomorrows, should be enough to render hundreds of millions of people awe-struck with happiness.
And **modern humans**, especially in the West, have every opportunity to be free, even as they enjoy ever-longer lives. Why is it, then, that so many people feel unhappy and trapped? The answer lies in the constant pressure of trying to meet needs that don't actually exist.
The word *need* has been used with less and less precision in modern life. Today, many things are described as needs, including fashion items, SUVs, vacations, and other luxuries**. People say, "I need a new car,"** when their current vehicle continues to function. People with many pairs of shoes may still say they "need" a new pair.
Clearly, this careless usage is inaccurate; neither the new car nor the additional shoes are truly "needed."

Key words:- Human history, people need, modern humans, people need car, shoes etc.

B. Business & Economics Passages

These passages are based on important Economic theories and business events. It is important for you to get acquainted with the language of business and economics, understanding the terminology from this field .Work on your business knowledge and vocabulary to be comfortable with these passages.

Sample Passage

On **inflation**, the risk to the upside comes from the severe El Nino conditions that we are facing, which is affecting weather conditions globally and the impact this could have on **food prices**. Another upside risk comes from the fact that higher growth means that the output gap is going to continue to narrow and in our forecast close at some point in 2016. So inflation might tend to tick up. Apart from that if the Pay Commission **wage hike** comes through and if **GST** comes through, both of them in the short term will be **inflationary** for the economy. So, there are risks to inflation, which are clearly skewed to the upside.

Key words: inflation, food prices, wage hike, food prices, GST etc.

C. Science Passages

These passages deal with areas such as biology, chemistry, medicine, technology and mathematics. These passages present a lot of facts, and since their subject matter is new to you, you might be bored by them. Do not get confused by the technical jargon and focus on the main ideas that are presented by the author of the passage.

Sample Passage

Not all of those **fossils** aged well. In one case, some smashed disarticulated **skeleton**s of a strange **reptile** were found in Italy and the Netherlands. These were classified 14 years ago as a particular species of reptile—*Eusaurosphargis dalsassoi*—but because the **fossils** were in such poor shape, researchers still weren't 100 percent sure what it looked like in its day. During an excavation at an altitude of 9,000 feet in Duncanfurgga, Switzerland, researchers found an impeccably preserved fossil of *Eusaurosphargis dalsassoi* mixed in with fish and marine reptile remains. When it was first uncovered 15 years ago, encased in rock, it was initially classified as a boring, run-of-the-mill fish. But after the fossil was carefully prepared and removed from some of its protective stone casing, **paleontologists** swiftly realized it wasn't a **fish** at all. Now, they can finally put a face to the name.

Key words: fossils, skeletons,reptile, paleontologists etc.

D. Liberal Arts Passages

These passages are related to philosophy, psychology. Such as language, philosophy, literature, abstract science) intended to provide chiefly general knowledge and to develop general intellectual capacities (such as reason and judgment) as opposed to professional or vocational skills. Generally, these passages are very dense and require immense focus for understanding them. Previous acquaintance with similar material will go a long way in disarming your resistance to this particular passage type. Generally, the questions based on these passages are focused on the overall picture, and check your general understanding of the concepts presented.

Sample Passage

"What does it feel like when you love something?" It's intensely moving when his interviewees offer an unfiltered version of motherhood and the **tangle of love** that comes with it. "I'm the only thing keeping this guy alive. It's all on me. Every call I make could be a life-and-death call," says one mother. "Despite being **profoundly happy** … I find myself in mourning for my old life. It's almost this grief that I've lost somebody and I think that somebody is myself."

There's a contrast **with mothers learning to let go of their teenagers**, but a feeling that the primal feelings of love are the same. "I find myself alone a lot," says a mum of teenagers, her voice wavering. "Kids, growing up, really think they know their parents, but they don't know them as people. They know them as parents," says another.

Key words: tangle of love, mothers feeling to let go teenagers etc.

E. Politics & Current Affairs

The passages from this area are based on current news, and these passages are by far the easiest to read. Since we are familiar with the topics, it becomes easy for us to understand what is happening and to follow the author of the passage. Though these passages are simple on most occasions, they can pose some tricky inferential questions at times. From the above analysis, you can identify the areas you are comfortable with and the ones that require work. The above classification gives you the power to understand your passage preference and the areas which require work from your side.

Sample Passage

Speaking after a day of bilateral discussions at the **G20 summit** in Hamburg, the prime minister said the UK had led on bolstering the **global fight** against terror and modern slavery as well as pushing for the implementation of the Paris agreement and **boosting international trade**.
On terrorism, Theresa May repeated past calls for world leaders to do more to disrupt international finance streams for terror groups and to help stop foreign fighters returning to the west from conflicts in Syria, Iraq and elsewhere. She also said the G20 agreed to do more to combat domestic violent extremism and welcomed moves from technology companies to address the online spread of extremist content.

Key words: G20 summit, global fight, on terrorism etc.

3.2 Practise test to recognise the subject area

Directions: In the following questions, excerpts from the passages have been given.
Identify key words and find out the subject area of the passage

Passage 1 - **(CAT 2006)**

Our propensity to look out for regularities, and to impose laws upon nature, leads to the psychological phenomenon of dogmatic thinking or, more generally, dogmatic behaviour: we expect regularities everywhere and attempt to find them even where there are none; events which do not yield to these attempts we are inclined to treat as a kind of background noise; and we stick to our expectations even when they are inadequate and we ought to accept defeat. This dogmatism is to some extent necessary. It is demanded by a situation which can only be dealt with by forcing our conjectures upon the world. Moreover, this dogmatism allows us to approach a good theory in stages, by way of approximations: if we accept defeat too easily, we may prevent ourselves from finding that we were very nearly right.

It is clear that this dogmatic attitude, which makes us stick to our first impressions, is indicative of a strong belief.

Key Words: _____

Area: _____

Passage 2 **(CAT 2008)**

I was fascinated, however, by some of my peers, whose parents bought them not a four-cent pie but two two-cent cones. These privileged children advanced proudly with one cone in their right hand and one in their left; and expertly moving their head from side to side, they licked first one, then the other. This liturgy seemed to me so sumptuously enviable, that many times I asked to be allowed to celebrate it. In vain. My elders were inflexible: a four-cent ice, yes; but two two-cent ones, absolutely no.

As anyone can see, neither mathematics nor economy nor dietetics justified this refusal. Nor did hygiene, assuming that in due course the tips of both cones were discarded. The pathetic, and obviously mendacious, justification was that a boy concerned with turning his eyes from one cone to the other was more inclined to stumble over stones, steps, or cracks in the pavement. I dimly sensed that there was another secret justification, cruelly pedagogical, but I was unable to grasp it.

Key words : _____

Area: _____

Passage 3 **(CAT 1999)**

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Key Words: _____

Area : _____

Passage 4 **(CAT 2004)**

Throughout human history the leading causes of death have been infection and trauma. Modern medicine has scored significant victories against both, and the major causes of ill health and death are now the chronic degenerative diseases, such as coronary artery disease, arthritis, osteoporosis, Alzheimer's, macular degeneration, cataract and cancer. These have a long latency period before symptoms appear and a diagnosis is made. It follows that the majority of apparently healthy people are pre-ill. But are these conditions inevitably degenerative? A truly preventive medicine that focused on the pre-ill, analysing the metabolic errors which lead to clinical illness, might be able to correct them before the first symptom. Genetic risk factors are known for all the chronic degenerative diseases, and are important to the individuals who possess them. At the population level, however, migration studies confirm that these illnesses are linked for the most part to lifestyle factors—exercise, smoking and nutrition. Nutrition is the easiest of these to change, and the most versatile tool for affecting the metabolic changes needed to tilt the balance away from disease.

Key words:_____

Area: _____

Passage 5 **(CAT 2004)**

Fifty feet away three male lions lay by the road. They didn't appear to have a hair on their heads. Noting the colour of their noses (leonine noses darken as they age, from pink to black), Craig estimated that they were six years old—young adults. "This is wonderful!" he said, after staring at them for several moments. "This is what we came to see. They really are maneless." Craig, a professor at the University of Minnesota, is arguably the leading expert on the majestic Serengeti lion, whose head is mantled in long, thick hair. He and Peyton West, a doctoral student who has been working with him in Tanzania, had never seen the Tsavo lions that live some 200 miles east of the Serengeti. The scientists had partly suspected that the maneless males were adolescents

mistaken for adults by amateur observers. Now they knew better. The Tsavo research expedition was mostly Peyton's show. She had spent several years in Tanzania, compiling the data she needed to answer a question that ought to have been answered long ago: Why do lions have manes? It's the only cat, wild or domestic, that displays such ornamentation. In Tsavo she was attacking the riddle from the opposite angle. Why do its lions not have manes? (Some "maneless" lions in Tsavo East do have partial manes, but they rarely attain the regal glory of the Serengeti lions'.) Does environmental adaptation account for the trait? Are the lions of Tsavo, as some people believe, a distinct subspecies of their Serengeti cousins?

Key words:_____

Area: _____

Passage 6 **(CAT 2016)**

Last year, a group of researchers decided to explore whether there were any policies aimed at emotional management in a workplace that would actually succeed. To answer that question, they had three hundred and eighty-two employees, from a number of retail stores, rate the degree of explicitness of the rules governing their emotional behavior at work: on the one end are vague, ambiguous admonitions such as “be positive,” without any guidelines; on the other end are explicit rules that govern when you should smile, what you should say, and the like. The researchers then observed how motivated the employees were and how customers responded to them.

What they found was an inverted-U relationship between rule explicitness and effectiveness: if rules were overly vague or overly prescriptive, they had a demotivating effect. (Customers, too, were disappointed, giving both employees and their shopping experiences lower ratings.) Where the rules generally had their intended effect was in the moderate range: when there were some explicit guidelines, but flexibility in how they were to be implemented. A second study, of a hundred and seventy-five salespeople, found the relationship to hold for sales numbers as well: sales were higher in environments with moderate rules, while environments with too few or too many rules suffered.

Key words: _____

Area: _____

3.3. Common subject area and source.

Let's have a look at few topics and the source from where they were picked up

Year	Article	Source
2015 CAT	Piketty's "Capital," in a Lot Less than 696 Pages by Justin Fox	Article from Harvard Business Review
	Starving for Wisdom by Nicholas Kristof	Article from New York Times
	World's poor need grid power, not just solar panels by Fred Pearce	Article from New Scientist
	The Ganga Water Crisis by Anthony Acciavatti	Article from New York Times
	Debunking the Myth of the Job-Stealing Immigrant y Adam Davidson	Article from New York Times
	Inca Road: the ancient highway that created an empire by Jane O'Brien	Article from BBC News
	The Web is here to Stay.	Article from New York Times
	Ritual Cosmetics and Status Transition: The Female Business Suit as Totemic emblem	Article from a Consumer Research Journal
2016 CAT	What Makes People Feel Upbeat at Work	http://www.newyorker.com/science/maria-konnikova
	The Case Against Repatriating Museum artifacts	http://www.outsidethebeltway.com/the-case-against-repatriating-museum-artifacts/
	London's super recognizer police force	http://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2016/08/22/londons-super-recognizer-police-force
	The Rebirth of Education: Schooling Ain't Learning	https://www.cgdev.org/
	What the World Will Speak in 2115	www.wsj.com/articles/what-the-world-will-speak-in-2115-1420234648

3.4 Type of articles to read on various subject areas

Below is the tentative list of sources from where should practice reading

1	Leading Newspapers of the World-	Purpose
	The Guardian (UK) ... The Wall Street Journal (USA) ... The New York Times (USA) ... The Washington Post (USA) ... China Daily (China) ... The Hindu (India) ... The Sydney Morning Herald (Australia) ... The Asahi Shimbun (Japan)	Articles on diverse topics and issues
2	Magazines-	
	Time Forbes The Economist Week Bloomberg Business Week Fortune INC. Customer Reports Fast Company Ad week	Business and Other Work Place related issues
3	Magazines-	
	The New Yorker	Culture and Society related articles
	The Artist	Art related Articles
	Art News	Art related Articles
	Art in America	Art related Articles
	Psychology Today	Psychology
	Wired	Technology and other areas affected by Technology
	National Geographic	Adventure
	Scientific American	Latest in Science
	In these Times	Current affairs
	The week	Current Affairs
	Current World Archaeology	Archaeology
	World War –II	War related incidents
	Harward Business Review	

For More information on what to read refer

a. www.hitbullseye.com
b. http://www.allyoucanread.com/newspapers/

Note: You may find some magazines that are paid subscriptions. But you can track some articles on their FB page or excerpts of these articles on the net free of cost.

3.5 How should I prepare

If you are a beginner

- Read something that interests you. It could be from any source.
- You can read from newspaper articles, blogs, internet, magazines etc.
- Read at least 3- 5 articles of your area of interest and try to summarize them in your own words.
- Make a record of your summary in a notebook
- Your immediate goal is to form a habit of reading, which will come by disciplined practice.
- Then gradually move to diverse topics and focus on comprehension

If you an average Reader

- Identify your current Reading style by making a note of –
    a) What do you read- What are the general reading areas
    b) How much time do you spend on reading
    c) What is your purpose of reading- (is it leisure, academic knowledge, comprehend etc.)
- Focus on moving to diverse topics and reading for ideas
- Focus on your comprehension skills

If you are a Good Reader

- Identify your current Reading status and make a note of
    a) Areas that you are comfortable reading
    b) Areas that you are not comfortable reading
    c) Your comprehension skills
    d) Your accuracy in Reading Comprehension skills
- Your goal should be to read challenging material (area you are not very comfortable with)
- Solve 2-3 CAT level passages everyday
- Focus on accuracy under simulated exam condition (on the computer and within specific time)

Chapter 4: Speed Reading Technique

4.1 Is speed important?

Speed of reading differs from person to person. What's important is a right balance of speed with comprehension. If you don't understand what you read than you are just wasting your time. But because the entrance test like CAT, XAT etc. are under time constraints and there are multiple questions to be attempted, you need to keep focus on speed as well.

Also, it shouldn't be too slow. Because when you read slowly it might happen that while reading some other simultaneous thoughts are flashing in front of you.

4.2 Check you speed

To start with, let us get an idea of your reading speed. Please time yourself on the passage below and find out how much time you took to read it.

PASSAGE

Write your start time _____

It has been a wonderful year for Hindi movies - suddenly, everybody is talking about the need for something called a 'script'. Even the producer who would spend Rs 30 lakh on one song and would gladly spend another Rs 2 crore on action sequences but would grudge paying the writer even Rs 2 lakhs, has begun to realise that great song sequences, great music, great action and even great stars cannot save his film, if it does not contain a 'story'.

I think it was Hitchcock who, in his inimitable style, talked about three most important elements necessary to make a successful movie: script, script and ..... script! And it was none other than Steven Spielberg who acknowledged that if the writers didn't write, everybody in Hollywood would be out of their jobs. And Robert Evans, the producer of such blockbusters as "The Godfather" would rather have the next five commitments from Robert Towne, (the legendary Hollywood script doctor who wrote 'Chinatown', arguably the greatest American screenplay) than the next five commitments from Robert Redford. Now compare this with the status of Bollywood writers. Where does a Bollywood writer stand today? Answers : Fifth from the left in the fourth row in any 'mahurat' photograph; somewhere below the knee of the star, sucking up to him, narrating a *dhansu* introduction scene just right for his ego; begging for his 50 per cent balance remuneration from a producer who claims to have suddenly gone bankrupt; begging the director not to steal his credit; hustling a successful director in the corridor of a 5-star hotel to narrate him six stories in five minutes flat!

Bollywood, which produces the maximum number of films in the world has may be, three thousand writers registered with its Film Writers Association out of which barely a dozen get regular work, and not more than six are actually busy. The busiest, however, are not even members of the Film Writers Association - Ms Laser

Disc and Mr VCR Swamy. Now compare this to Hollywood where every University has a film course, every city has film schools and dozens of regular script workshops organised to teach script writing, which produce, on an average, may be three thousand writers every year!

So is it a wonder that even the biggest blockbuster of the year can be best remembered only for its tolerable music and interior decoration? Is it a wonder that the box office has proved to be the graveyard of most visual stylists? Is it a wonder that the audience seems to have graduated but the film markers are still stuck in the fourth grade? Is it a wonder that the most 'agonising' moral choice our heroes are burdened with is whether to pick up an AK-47 or an AK-56? And what about dilemmas? Well, there is no dilemma too big for a portable stereo and a Ganesha to solve!

Whatever ails Hindi movies, I hope it gets worse. Because things change only when they reach the extreme water turns to steam only at 100 degree C, not even at 99.99 degree C. And because I love Hindi movies, because I love being a writer of Hindi films, because I believe a writer is the first star of a film, not its last priority.

Stop: Now Note Down The Time You Took To Read The Passage

Refer to the table below to calculate your reading speed in words per minute (WPM):

Time	WPM	Time	WPM	Time	WPM
30 s	1090	2 min 40 s	204	4 min 40 s	117
45 s	727	2 min 50 s	192	4 min 50 s	113
1 min	545	3 min	182	5 min	109
1 min 10 s	467	3 min 10 s	172	5 min 10 s	105
1 min 20 s	409	3 min 20 s	164	5 min 20 s	102
1 min 30 s	363	3 min 30 s	156	5 min 30 s	99
1 min 40 s	327	3 min 40 s	149	5 min 40 s	96
1 min 50 s	297	3 min 50 s	142	5 min 50 s	93
2 min	273	4 min	136	6 min	91
2 min 10 s	252	4 min 10 s	131	6 min 10 s	88
2 min 20 s	234	4 min 20 s	126	6 min 20 s	86
2 min 30 s	218	4 min 30 s	121	6 min 30 s	84

Now that you have a benchmark, make it a point to calculate your reading speed by approximating the number of words and dividing it by the time taken in minutes to read the passage. This passage had 545 words in all.

4.3 Techniques to improve reading speed

Requirement:

1. Book to read
2. Watch/ Stop clock
3. Pen/ pencil
4. Your current speed of reading
5. Your Approach to the Course:
   - attitude—having a positive outlook, trust, and a willing suspension of disbelief
   - motivation—keeping your goals in mind and being disciplined with practice even if you do not experience immediate results.

Technique 1: Trackers and Pacers

Why use this Method:

To avoid regression i.e to read the lines by going back every time. The duration of fixations can be minimized by using a tracker and pacer.

Holding the pen in your dominant hand, you will underline each line (with the cap on), keeping your eye fixation above the tip of the pen.

This will not only serve as a tracker, but it will also serve as a pacer for maintaining consistent speed and decreasing fixation duration.

Requirements

You will need: a book of 200+ pages that can lay flat when open, a pen, and a timer (a stop watch with alarm is ideal). You should complete the 20 minutes of exercises in one session

Technique for using Tracker and Pacer

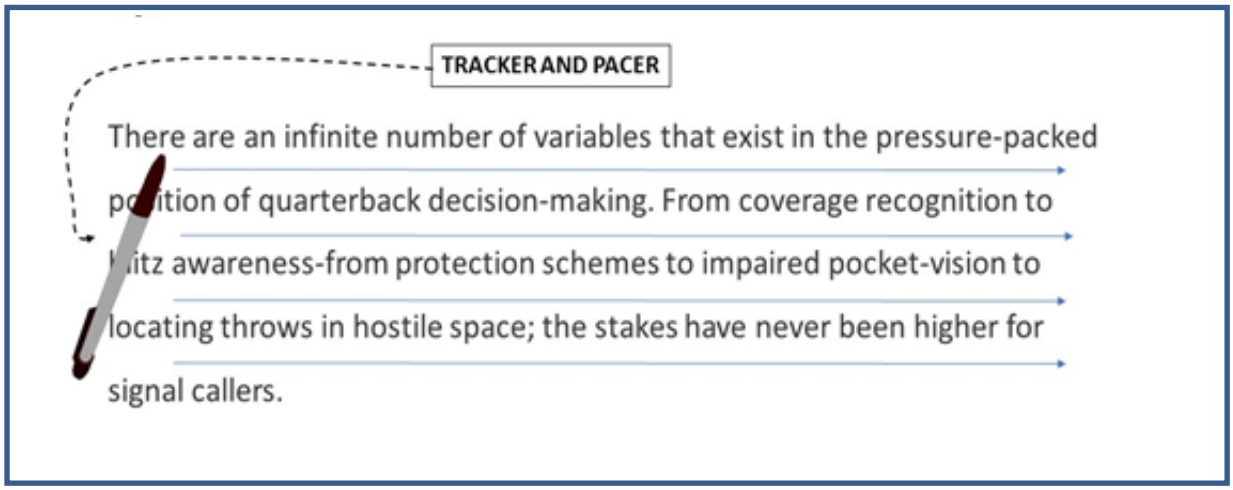
1) Step 1 (Practise for 2 minutes)

A. Practice using the pen as a tracker and pacer.

B. Underline each line, focusing above the tip of the pen.

C. Do not concern yourself with comprehension.

D. Keep each line to a maximum of one second, and increase the speed with each subsequent page. Read, but under no circumstances should you take longer than one second per line.



Step 2: Build Speed (3 minutes):

A. Repeat the technique, keeping each line to no more than one-half second (two lines for a single second).

B. Some will comprehend nothing, which is to be expected. Don't worry.

C. Maintain speed and technique-you are conditioning your perceptual reflexes, and this is a speed exercise designed to facilitate adaptations in your system.

D. Do not decrease speed. One-half second per line for three minutes; focus above the pen and concentrate on technique with speed. Focus on the exercise, and do not daydream.

Step 3: Practise for 20 mins

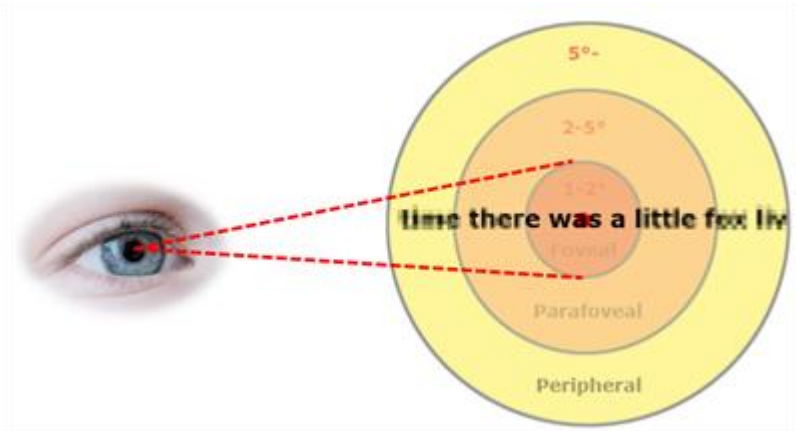
Step 4: Now check your speed.

Technique 2: Perceptual Expansion

Why use this method

According to Tim Ferriss, an average reader who reads from the 1st word to the last word of each line, are only using 50% of their peripheral vision.

The way to improve your peripheral vision is what Ferriss calls Perceptual Expansion.



Training peripheral vision to register more effectively can increase reading speed over Untrained readers use up to one-half of their peripheral field on margins by moving from first word to last, spending 25-50 percent of their time "reading" margins with no content. This concept is easy to implement and combine with the tracking and pacing you've already practiced.

To illustrate, let us take the hypothetical one line:

"Once upon a time, students enjoyed reading four hours a day."

If you were able to begin your reading at "time" and finish the line at "four," you would eliminate 6 of 11 words, more than doubling your reading speed.

We'll break down this reading exercise in 2 simple steps:

Step 1: Technique (one minute):

a.Use the pen to track and pace at a consistent speed of one line per second. Begin one word in from the first word of each line, and end one word in from the last word.

b.Do not concern yourself with comprehension.

c.Keep each line to a maximum of one second, and increase the speed with each subsequent page.

d. Read, but under no circumstances should you take longer than one second per line.

Step 2: Technique (one minute):

a. Use the pen to track and pace at a consistent speed of one line per second.

b. Begin two words in from the first word of each line, and end two words in from the last word.

Step 3: Speed (three minutes):

Begin at least three words in from the first word of each line, and end three words in from the last word. Repeat the technique, keeping each line to no more than one-half second .

Note: Some will comprehend nothing, which is to be expected. Maintain speed and technique-you are conditioning your perceptual reflexes, and this is a speed exercise designed to facilitate adaptations in your system. Do not decrease speed. One-half second per line for three minutes; focus above the pen and concentrate on technique with speed. Focus on the exercise, and do not daydream.

Step 4: Calculate New WPM Reading Speed

Mark your first line and read with a timer for one minute exactly. Read at your fastest comprehension rate.

Chapter 5: Techniques to improve Comprehension

5.1 Why comprehension is important

Have you ever read a whole page of text and then wondered, that I have no clue what I just read. There is no comprehension or understanding at all of what we have read. We read in speed and then keep going back to looking for each and every answer. While we are reading unfamiliar topic, we are distracted and get bored. All this happens due to poor comprehension skills.

Why do we need to focus on comprehending the passage. It's simple, most of the questions asked in Reading Comprehension are of the following type-

1. What is the main idea/ central idea of the passage
2. What is the structure of the passage
3. What is the tone of the author
4. What do you infer from the passage
5. Do you agree/ disagree with author's claim
6. What is the purpose of the passage etc.

All these questions pertain to the entire theme of the passage rather than on one fact or one idea. We should be able to look at the bigger picture and find out what is the author talking about. Hence, comprehension is very important to solve these questions and also to improve your scores.

Comprehension also helps you in critical reasoning questions

5.2 Technique to improve comprehension

A. Note making Technique

Here's how it works. You read a paragraph and then, take a quick note of what you just read. Then you simply repeat this process, read a paragraph, take a note. Read another paragraph, take another note. These notes should be quick. Just write a word or a phrase that describes the content in that paragraph.

Effective process for taking notes while reading. It aids your memory, and if you really need to remember what you are reading you probably should be

Learn to take notes faster and more efficiently.

- Keep your notes concise.
- Write ideas not sentences (This is a simple way to speed up your note-taking, but it's surprising how many people ignore this advice…and try to write complete sentences…while they're taking notes. If you do this, you may end up wasting time.)
- Keep your notes to keywords and phrases

- Write down only what's absolutely necessary.(Not everything is equally important….Many times there are two, three,…or four major points being made….Don't get bogged down with the detail….If you're paying attention, you'll remember the details…because the bigger concepts will trigger that information)
- Avoid excessive highlighting and too many notes.(Have you ever bought a used college textbook,…and noticed ridiculous amounts of highlighting)
- "When you get caught…"up in details, you lose sight of the big picture." This is one of the biggest issues when it comes to note-taking. People get caught up in details.
- A better way to handle this would be…to finish reading the paragraph and then decide…

This two -step process will help

Step 1 Preview: Get familiar with the material. During the step, you simply read the introduction and conclusion. If you're reading a short article, this could simply be the first and last paragraph. If you're reading something longer like a book chapter or a detailed blog post, this could be a few paragraphs at the beginning, and a few at the end.

Step 2 Jot Key ideas : Take Important key ideas .Write down the first thing that come to mind….What was most memorable?…What is the main point of what you're reading?…Keep your notes concise….Just a word or short phrase should be enough…

Practise Exercise

Step 1- Read this one page article. If you're working on printed paper, you can write each note next to the adjacent paragraph. If you're reading from the computer screen, jot those notes on a separate sheet of paper.

Your notes should be concise.

Keep each note to just one word or short phrase to describe what the paragraph was about.

Step 2 -Read each paragraph, take a note, and repeat until you finish the article

Sample Passage - 1

Occasional self-medication has always been part of normal living. The making and selling of drugs has a long history and is closely linked, like medical practice itself, with belief in magic. Only during the last hundred years or so, as the development of scientific techniques made it possible diagnosis has become possible. The doctor is now able to follow up the correct diagnosis of many illnesses-with specific treatment of their causes. In many other illnesses of which the causes remain unknown, he is still limited, like the unqualified prescriber, to the treatment of symptoms. The doctor is trained to decide when to treat symptoms only and when to attack the cause. This is the essential difference between medical prescribing and self-medication.

The advance of technology has brought about much progress in some fields of medicine, including the development of scientific drug therapy. In many countries public health organization is improving and people's nutritional standards have risen. Parallel with such beneficial trends are two which have an adverse effect. One is the use of high pressure advertising by the pharmaceutical industry which has tended to influence both patients and doctors and has led to the overuse of drugs generally. The other is emergence of eating, insufficient sleep, excessive smoking and drinking. People with disorders arising from faulty habits such as these , as well as well from unhappy human relationships , often resort to self –medication and so add the taking of pharmaceuticals to the list .Advertisers go to great lengths to catch this market.

Clever advertising, aimed at chronic suffers who will try anything because doctors have not been able to cure them, can induce such faith in a preparation, particularly if steeply priced, that it will produce-by suggestion-a very real effect in some people .Advertisements are also aimed at people suffering from mild complaints such as simple cold and coughs which clear up by themselves within a short time.

These are the main reasons, why laxatives, indigestion-remedies, painkillers, cough-mixtures, tonics, vitamin and iron tablets, nose drops, ointments and many other preparations are found in quantity in many households. It is doubtful whether taking these things ever improves a person's health, it may even make it worse. Worse, because the preparation may contain unsuitable ingredients; worse because the taker may become dependent on them; worse because they might be taken excess; worse because they may cause poisoning , and worst of all because symptoms of some serious underlying cause may be asked and therefore medical help may not be sought. Self-diagnosis is a greater danger than self-medication.

	Key idea	Supporting ideas
Para 1	Self medication	(a) part of normal living—last 100 yrs (b) Advance in diag tech.. (c) Drs rqd. for diag .& treatmnt of disease (d) self-medication differs from medical prescription
Para 2	Technological Advmnt. in medicine	(a) drug therapy (b)impvt. In pub. Health org' (c) increase in nutri'l standards.
Para 3	Clever advertising by Pharma companies	(a)take advantage of people's need (b) chronic suffers (c) mild complaints like cold and coughs (d) Faulty life style (i) Lack of exercise, over eating, insuff't sleep etc. (ii) stress, unhappy rela'ps etc.
Para 4	dangers of self – medi'n. ss	a) Prep'n contain unsuitable ingre (b) Taker becomes dependent (c) Taker consumes medi. In excess (d) Prep'ns may cause poison'g (e) Real cause of illness gets suppressed or untreated.

Summary: Self-medication is dangerous as the preparation may be toxic or contain unsuitable ingredients, the user becomes dependent and consumes medicine in excess. Self-diagnosis is worse than self-medication. Self-medication is part of normal living. Medicinal experts are required for diagnosis and treatment of disease according to symptoms and cause.

The development of drug therapy and improvement in public health organizations and nutritional standards have helped progress in medicinal science. Excessive advertising by pharmaceutical companies and emergence of the sedentary society are two counter trends.

Sample Passage – 2

Almost all of us have suffered from a headache at some time or the other. For some a headache is a constant companion and life is a painful hell of wasted time.

The most important step to cope with headaches is to identify the type of headache one is suffering from. In tension headaches (two hand headache), a feeling of a tight band around the head exits along with the pain in the neck and shoulders. It usually follows activities such as long stretches driving, typing or sitting on the desks. They are usually short lived but can also last for days or weeks.

A headache is usually caused due to the spinal misalignment of the head, due to the posture. Sleeping on the stomach with the head turn to one side and bending over positions for a long time make it worse.

In migraine headaches, the pains usually on one side of the head may be accompanied by nausea, vomiting irritability and bright spots of flashes of light. This headache is meant worse by activities especially bending. The throbbing pain in the head worsens by noise and light. Certain triggers for migraines may be chocolate, caffeine, smoking or MSU in certain food items. The pain may last eight to twenty four hours and there may be a hangover for two or three days. Migraines are often produced by an 'aura'------ changes in sight and sensation. There is usually a family migraine.

In a headache, pain originates from the brain but from the irritated nerves of muscles, blood vessels and bones. These head pain signals to the brain which judges the degree of distress and relays it at appropriate sites. The pain sometimes may be referred to sights other than the problem areas. This is known as referred by pain and occurs due to sensation overload. Thus, though, most headache states at the base of the skull referred pain as felt typically behind the eyes.

Factors causing headache are understood but it is known that a shift in the level of body hormones chemicals, certain foods and drinks and environmental stress can trigger them.

If the headache troubles you often, visit the doctor, who will take a full health history relating to diet, life stresses, the type of headache, trigging factors and relief measures. You may be asked to keep a 'headache diary' which tells you to list – the time headache started and when it ended, emotional environmental and food and drinking factors which may contribute to it. The type and severity of pain and the medications used which provide much relief are also to be listed.
This helps the doctor in determining the exact cause and type of headache and the remedy thereof.

	Key idea	Supporting ideas
Para 1	Identification	(i) tension headache, or (ii) migraine headache
Para 2	Symptoms	i) Tension headaches (a) feeling tight band around head (b) pain in neck and shoulders (ii) Migraine headaches (a) pain on one side of the head (b) vomiting and irritability (c) bright sport of flashes of light
Para 3	Causes	(i) Tension headaches (a) long stretches of driving (b) long hours of typing or sitting on the desk (ii) Migraine headache. (a) Chocolate, coffee, smoking. (b) MSU is certain food items
Para 4	Treatment	(i) Self –care techniques for shorter period. (ii) Doctor advice for permanent treatments.

Summary: Life becomes a painful hell if headache becomes once constants companion. In order to find an effective cure for it, is very important to identify the type of headache one suffering from. It can be tension headache or a migraine, and the treatment as to be found as accordingly. Complete 'headache diary' if maintained may help the doctor find the perfect remedy to triggering factors responsible for it. Self-medication should be done for only a short-term relief and with the greatest caution. Doctor's advice is a must if it persists for a longer time.

Sample Passage – 3

CAT 2007

Human Biology does nothing to structure human society. Age may enfeeble us all, but cultures vary considerably in the prestige and power they accord to the elderly. Giving birth is a necessary condition for being a mother, but it is not sufficient. We expect mothers to behave in maternal ways and to display appropriately maternal sentiments. We prescribe a clutch of norms or rules that govern the role of a mother. That the social role is independent of the biological base can be demonstrated by going back three sentences. Giving birth is certainly not sufficient to be a mother but, as adoption and fostering show, it is not even necessary!

Key idea:- No relation between biological role and social role

The fine detail of what is expected of a mother or a father or a dutiful son differs from culture to culture, but everywhere behaviour is coordinated by the reciprocal nature of roles. Husbands and wives, parents and

children, employers and employees, waiters and customers, teachers and pupils, warlords and followers; each makes sense only in its relation to the other. The term 'role' is an appropriate one, because the metaphor of an actor in a play neatly expresses the rule-governed nature or scripted nature of much of social life and the sense that society is a joint production. Social life occurs only because people play their parts (and that is as true for war and conflicts as for peace and love) and those parts make sense only in the context of the overall show. The drama metaphor also reminds us of the artistic licence available to the players. We can play a part straight or, as the following from J.P. Sartre conveys, we can ham it up.

Key idea: Behaviour is coordinated by reciprocal roles

Let us consider this waiter in the cafe. His movement is quick and forward, a little too precise, a little too rapid. He comes towards the patrons with a step a little too quick. He bends forward a little too eagerly; his voice, his eyes express an interest a little too solicitous for the order of the customer. Finally there he returns, trying to imitate in his walk the inflexible stiffness of some kind of automaton while carrying his tray with the recklessness of a tightrope-walker....All his behaviour seems to us a game....But what is he playing? We need not watch long before we can explain it: he is playing at being a waiter in a cafe.

Key idea: Behaviour of the waiter due to his job role

The American sociologist Erving Goffman built an influential body of social analysis on elaborations of the metaphor of social life as drama. Perhaps his most telling point was that it is only through acting out a part that we express character. It is not enough to be evil or virtuous; we have to be seen to be evil or virtuous.

Key idea: Acting out a part we display a certain character

There is distinction between the roles we play and some underlying self. Here we might note that some roles are more absorbing than others. We would not be surprised by the waitress who plays the part in such a way as to signal to us that she is much more than her occupation. We would be surprised and offended by the father who played his part 'tongue in cheek'. Some roles are broader and more far-reaching than others. Describing someone as a clergyman or faith healer would say far more about that person than describing someone as a bus driver.

Key idea: Distinction between our acting roles and underlying self

5.3 Creating Visual Maps

A. Mind Maps

What are mind maps:

A visual or a pictorial ways of taking down notes while reading are called as Mind Maps. A great way to organize non-linear information is to take notes visually.

Suitable For:

The topics of business, law, physics, medicine etc. where information is not presented in a linear way and is not in a set specific order. You don't need to remember it in a set order. You just need to know that all of the concepts and details are associated with a single topic. A great way to organize non-linear information is to take notes visually.

Generally, when we discuss topics on history, they are written in a linear based structure. Outlines are also very linear in that they assume Roman numeral number two comes after Roman numeral number one. Flow chart way of taking notes are most appropriate for information that runs in a specific sequence, like history, or for instructional information that may contain a step one, step two and so on.

Why use Mind Maps

- Mind maps are effective at helping you remember things.
- It's kind of having a bird's eye view of the information, and later if you need to review the information it's very easy to see the structure and detail.
- Helps you understand how the information is associated

How to make mind maps

Mind maps consist of a central idea in the middle. If you were taking notes while reading, this might be the title of your chapter with nodes extending from that central idea. Their surrounding boxes or bubbles could be headings and subheadings within your chapter, or main points from the material you are reading. Mind maps can include colour and other visuals to help you remember even more effectively. Just make sure your note taking reflects the way in which the information is structured

Chapter 6– Reading Better and Faster

6.1 Six Canons of Better and Faster Comprehension

To achieve your goal of faster reading speed and understanding, pay close attention to these important rules:

1. Read More and More

You will have to read much, much more than you are now doing. If you are a slow reader, you most likely go through the daily papers and light magazines. You read whenever you happen to have a few spare minutes, you read merely to pass time. Or perhaps you hardly ever read at all unless you must.

From now on, you must take time for reading. Speed can be developed into a permanent habit only if you do what naturally fast and skillful readers have always done, from childhood on: read a lot. That means at least a full book every week. Unless you develop the habit of reading for two hours or more at a stretch, several stretches every week, don't expect ever to become an efficient reader.

2. Learn to Read for Main Ideas

Stop wasting time and effort on details. When you read, push through efficiently for quick recognition of the main idea that the details support and illustrate; be more interested in the writer's basic thinking than in minor points.

When you read, be intent on getting the theme, the broad ideas, and the framework on which the author has built the book. Don't let an occasional perplexing paragraph slow you down. Keep speeding through. As the complete picture is filled in by rapid overall reading, the few puzzling details will either turn out to be unimportant or will be cleared as you move along.

When you read a short story or a novel, follow the thread of the plot, consciously look for and find the "conflict" skim whenever you feel impelled to – don't meander in from word to word and sentence to sentence.

3. Challenge Your Comprehension

Fast readers are good readers. They're fast because they have learned to understand print quickly, and they understand quickly because they give themselves constant practice in understanding. To this end, they read challenging material: and you must do the same. Does a novel sound deep? Does a book of nonfiction seem difficult? Does an article in a magazine look as if it will require more thinking than you feel prepared to do? Then that's the type of reading that will give you the most valuable training.

You will never become a better reader by limiting yourself to easy reading – you cannot grow intellectually by pampering yourself. Ask yourself: "Do I know more about myself and the rest of world, as a result of my reading, than I did in the past?" If your honest answer is no, then you should get started on a more challenging type of reading.

4. Budget Your Time

Say to yourself: "I have five chapters in sociology, anthropology, psychology (or whatever) to read by next week". And then give yourself a limited, specific time in which to complete the assignment: for example, three chapters tonight, in two hours (allowing time for underlining, writing in the margin, taking notes etc.) and two chapters tomorrow night, in an hour and a half.

Good readers always have a feeling of going fast, for they have developed fast habits, indeed, adults and college students who have trained themselves to read rapidly would find their original slow pace uncomfortable and unpleasant.

5. Pace Yourself

When you start a new book, read for quick understanding for 15 minutes. Count the number of pages you've finished in that time, multiply by 4, and you have your potential speed for that book in pages per hour. (Of course some books are slower reading than others - it takes more time to cover 50 pages in a college text than in a light novel. The more solidity packed in the ideas there on a page, the more time it will take to cover that page.)

Keep to the rate you've set for yourself in pages per hour. In this way, you will learn to devise personal tricks that will speed you up and that will, at the same time, sharpen your comprehension skill. But you must practice every day or nearly every day, if you wish to make high speed natural and automatic, if you wish to become efficient in rapid comprehension.

6. Develop Habits of Immediate Concentration

Nothing makes concentration so easy, so immediate, as the technique of sweeping through material purposefully looking for main ideas and broad concepts. All people of normal intelligence can concentrate when they read, but slow readers put themselves at a disadvantage.

If, through laziness, you read at a slower rate than the rate at which you are able to comprehend, there is great temptation for your mind to wander. The brightest persons in a class are not always the best students. If the work is too easy for them, they become bored, they think of more interesting things, they daydream, they stop paying attention. This analogy explains why a slower reader picks up a book or a magazine, goes through a few pages, and finding that attention is wandering, puts it down and turns to something else.
By reading always at your top comprehension speed, you constantly challenge your understanding, you stimulate your mind, and you get involved in the author's thoughts without half trying.

And, as an added dividend, you soon find that the increased concentration you get from fast, aggressive reading sharpens your understanding and enjoyment, for every distracting thought is pushed out of your mind. But reading about the principles of efficient and rapid comprehension is not going to make you faster or better reader. Only putting those principles into practice, over a period of time, can do that for you.

How long will it take? That depends on what sort of person you are and how assiduously you apply yourself under prime conditions, habits of speed and aggressive comprehension can become automatic after a few months of daily, or almost daily, practice. People have practically proved it year after year.

The important thing is that you now realize that you have the ability to read faster than you generally do.

Urgency Is The Name of The Game

If you read at a rate between 175-250 WPM, you may have formed habits of wandering through print in a random, purposeless way, letting words and ideas wash over you, making no demands on what you are reading – *irrespective of the material type*.

It is possible, with such habits, that you permit yourself the luxury of being distracted by your surroundings; you are in no hurry to get anywhere because you have no awareness of where you wish to go; and you often passively - even blankly - follow words, your mind only partial engaged, instead of aggressively *asking question and demanding answers*.

You are, in brief, *uncommitted and over relaxed when you read*. As a result, you rarely stay with a book for more than 30-60 minutes at a time, for passivity leads to boredom, and boredom is so unpleasant that it is natural to avoid it.
Take the first step toward learning to attack all your reading, of whatever purpose, with a sense of urgency.

Exercises In Accurate Response

Have a pen or pencil at hand for ticking options. Set your stopwatch or timer, for exactly 1/2 minute! In the short period of 90 seconds, you are to read each selection and then mark five statements about it - true or false.

Do the true – false test without referring again to what you have read. Do not guess. If you cannot decide, leave the answer blank. Note that you are to try to finish both the selections and the test in 90 seconds or less.

6.2 10 Tips that form The Basis of Reading

Reading of all types opens up vistas of knowledge at any level. A child in the nursery learns about the magic of the sky, sun and the stars by visual and actual reading. As we grow, we learn the basics of life by reading about them. But sadly reading is not everyone's cup of tea. In this final section, we share with you a few fundamental tips to help improve your reading habits.

1. You don't need to understand each and every word.

Read little but absorb what you read. The requirement of everyone depends on their environment and level of intelligence. As long as reading material is available and it satisfies your mind you should enjoy reading and grasp the main subject. The rest will automatically fall into place. The point is to get the central idea, the core concept; the specifics can be given a miss.

2. Identify your purpose of reading

Many reasons can contribute to the quest for become a better reader. Why are you reading? It could be for an examination purpose, or to put an impression about the extent of your knowledge, or perhaps find a foothold amongst your peers. The main purpose for you should be accumulation of knowledge through extensive reading; there is a saying that knowledge gained can never be lost. IDENTIFY ONE PIECE OF KNOWLEDGE that you like to learn from every piece you would read.

3. What to choose for reading

Time is valuable commodity so one has to make an informed choice with respect to what one reads. Chalk out the important areas and pay full attention to them. Extra, nonsensical material should be avoided. Junk magazines and blogs can be rejected.

4. Read only the top-end material

Whatsoever you choose to read make sure it is the best. Classify all that you have selected to read and then go in only for the best.

5. Scrutinize before starting

Generally, most of us pick up a book or a magazine and judge it by its cover without going through the contents; and read the ones that appeal to us. This is a wrong method; go through the contents before beginning to read. By doing so you save yourself the trouble of reading B–grade material.

6. List your preferences

A person feels elated at having a pile of material to read. Prioritize the most important ones and leave the rest to the end of the pile. Having a well-organized pile would make you even more happy.

7. The environment should be conducive and pleasant

If the mind is at rest it will absorb more, and thus another important factor which helps in encouraging you to read is a pleasant and peaceful surrounding.

8. Finish what you start

Leaving an article or a book midway does not help you. If some parts are difficult go back to them again , but finish what you have started. This way you tend to exercise your brain more and attain more knowledge.

9. Maintain your focus

Focus generates interest and vice versa; if you find something interesting naturally you will retain more. Getting engrossed in the reading material will help you greatly increase your efficiency.

10. Last but not the least:

Only one thing can make you better at reading: reading more!

Chapter 7 – RC Practice

Let us try to apply the learning

In the following passages, summarize the each para of the given passages
Correct:-__Read each passage given below at a time.

a. Identify the topic of the passage
b. Summarise each paragraph in one line

Passage - 1

In pre-penicillin 1937, medicine was cheap and very ineffective. If you were in a hospital it was going to do you good only because it offered you some warmth, some food, shelter, and the caring attention of a nurse. Doctors and medicine made no difference at all. This was when the core structure of medicine was created – what it meant to be good at what we did and how we wanted to build medicine to be. If you had a prescription pad, if you had a nurse, if you had a hospital that would give you a place to convalesce, maybe some basic tools, you really could do it all. This was a life as a craftsman. As a result, we built it around a culture and set of values that said what you were good at was being daring, at being courageous, at being independent and self-sufficient. Autonomy was our highest value.

Well, we've now discovered 4,000 medical procedures. We've discovered 6,000 drugs. And we've reached the point where we've realized, as doctors, we can't know it all. We're all specialists now. But holding onto that structure we built around the daring, independence, self-sufficiency of each of those people has become a disaster. We have trained, hired and rewarded people to be cowboys. But it's pit crews that we need, pit crews for patients.

As we've looked at the data about the results that have come as the complexity has increased, we found that the most expensive care is not necessarily the best care. And vice versa, the best care often turns out to be the least expensive. But when we look at the positive deviants -- the ones who are getting the best results at the lowest costs -- we find the ones that look the most like systems are the most successful. Having great components is not enough, and yet we've been obsessed in medicine with components. We want the best drugs, the best technologies, the best specialists, but we don't think too much about how it all comes together.

In a system, however, when things start to come together, you realize it has certain skills for acting and looking that way. Skill number one is the ability to recognize success and the ability to recognize failure. When you are a specialist, you can't see the end result very well. You have to become really interested in data. I got interested in this when the World Health Organization came to my team asking if we could help with a project to reduce deaths in surgery. Now our usual tactics for tackling problems like these are to do more training, give people more specialization or bring in more technology.

Well in surgery, you couldn't have people who are more specialized and you couldn't have people who are better trained. And yet we see unconscionable levels of death, disability that could be avoided. And so we looked at what other high-risk industries do. We looked at skyscraper construction, we looked at the aviation world, and we found that they have technology, they have training, and then they have one other thing: They have checklists. We got the lead safety engineer for Boeing to help us.

Could we design a checklist for surgery? What they taught us was that designing a checklist to help people handle complexity actually involves more difficulty than I had understood. You have to think about things like pause points. You need to identify the moments in a process when you can actually catch a problem before it's a danger and do something about it. You have to identify that this is a before-takeoff checklist. And then you need to focus on the killer items. We created a 19-item two-minute checklist for surgical teams. We had the pause points immediately before anesthesia is given, immediately before the knife hits the skin, immediately before the patient leaves the room. Also checks for making sure an antibiotic is given in the right time frame because that cuts the infection rate by half or making sure everyone in the room had introduced themselves by name at the start of the day.

We implemented this checklist in eight hospitals around the world, deliberately in places from rural Tanzania to the University of Washington in Seattle. We found that after they adopted it the complication rates fell 35 percent. It fell in every hospital it went into. The death rates fell 47 percent. This was bigger than a drug.
Extracted from a TED talk by AtulGawande

Passage - 2

Although websites such as Facebook and MySpace experienced exponential growth during the middle of the first decade of the 21st century, some users remain oblivious to the fact that the information they post online can come back to haunt them. First, employers can monitor employees who maintain a blog, photo diary, or website. Employers can look for controversial employee opinions, sensitive information disclosures, or wildly inappropriate conduct. For example, a North Carolina newspaper fired one of its features writers after she created a blog on which she anonymously wrote about the idiosyncrasies of her job and coworkers.

The second unintended use of information from social networking websites is employers who check on prospective employees. A June 11, 2006 New York Times article reported that many companies recruiting on college campuses use search engines and social networking websites such as MySpace, Xanga, and Facebook to conduct background checks. Although the use of MySpace or Google to scrutinize a student’s background is somewhat unsettling to many undergraduates, the Times noted that the utilization of Facebook is especially shocking to students who believe that Facebook is limited to current students and recent alumni.

Corporate recruiters and prospective employers are not the only people interested in college students' lives. The third unintended use of social networking websites is college administrators who monitor the Internet – especially Facebook – for student misconduct. For example, a college in Boston's Back Bay expelled its student Government Association President for joining a Facebook group highly critical of a campus police sergeant. In addition, fifteen students at a state university in North Carolina faced charges in court for underage drinking because of photos that appeared on Facebook.

Although more users of websites such as Facebook are becoming aware of the potential pitfalls of online identities, many regular users still fail to take three basic security precautions. First, only make your information available to a specific list of individuals whom you approve. Second, regularly search for potentially harmful information about yourself that may have been posted by mistake or by a disgruntled former associate. Third, never post blatantly offensive material under your name or on your page as, despite the best precautions, this material will likely make its way to the wider world. By taking these simple steps, members of the digital world can realize the many benefits of e-community without experiencing some of the damaging unintended consequences.

Passage -3

The principal facts about the exploits of the English and French buccaneers of the seventeenth century in the West Indies are sufficiently well known to modern readers. The French Jesuit historians of the Antilles have left us many interesting details of their mode of life, and Exquemelin's history of the freebooters has been reprinted numerous times both in France and in England. Based upon these old, contemporary narratives, modern accounts are issued from the press with astonishing regularity, some of them purporting to be serious history, others appearing in the more popular and entertaining guise of romances. All, however, are alike in confining themselves for their information to what may almost be called the traditional sources--Exquemelin, the Jesuits, and perhaps a few narratives like those of Dampier and Wafer.

To write another history of these privateers or pirates, for they have, unfortunately, more than once deserved that name, may seem a rather fruitless undertaking. It is justified only by the fact that there exist numerous other documents bearing upon the subject, documents which till now have been entirely neglected. Exquemelin has been reprinted, the story of the buccaneers has been re-told, yet no writer, editor, or historian has attempted to estimate the trustworthiness of the old tales by comparing them with these other sources, or to show the connection between the buccaneers and the history of the English colonies in the West Indies.

The object of this research, therefore, is not only to give a narrative, according to the most authentic, available sources, of the more brilliant exploits of these sea-rovers, but, what is of greater interest and importance, also to trace the policy pursued towards them by the English and the French Governments

Passage -4

What is the biggest lesson from the Great Depression? In my view, it is that monetary policy and the financial sector play a crucial role in economic development. One important component of the monetary policy is the financial market, more specifically the banking sector.

Why are financial markets and the banking sector so important? Banks fulfil a very important role in the economy by matching borrowers and lenders. When we deposit $100 in a bank, the bank keeps, at most, two to three dollars in its vaults (some of this is actually kept with the central bank), the remaining $98 or so are lent to a borrower.

Most businesses require loans for their normal operations. When the banking sector does not work properly, businesses cannot get loans and they have to curtail their production and lay off workers. As they curtail production, they demand fewer products from their suppliers and therefore their suppliers have to reduce their output and fire workers. If manufacturers cannot sell their goods because the firm downstream does not need as many products as before, they cannot generate enough revenue to repay their earlier loans. Businesses go bankrupt and banks experience further problems as their balance sheet deteriorates due to non-performing loans. At this point, banks want to lend even less because of the uncertainty generated from bankruptcies. As they lend less, the vicious circle continues – with producers cutting production and firing workers. On top of this, depositors start worrying about their deposits because the non-performing loans have made some banks go belly up – your bank has lent out your money to borrowers who cannot return it. Depositors start withdrawing their cash and banks have even fewer possibilities for lending as they have to hoard cash in case there is a run on the bank. If the financial sector does not work, the real economy can go into a deadly spiral and shrink by 30 per cent as during the Great Depression.

One would have thought that this fact would be obvious to all the policy makers. However all the lessons from the Great Depression seem to have been lost within three-quarters of a century. It seems, to paraphrase Marc Bard, that politics (especially of the petty and partisan variety) eats policy for lunch seven days a week

Passage -5

Although I am familiar with Rembrandt's work, through photographs and black and white reproductions, I invariably experience a shock from the colour standpoint whenever I come in touch with one of his pictures. I was especially struck with that masterpiece of his at the Hermitage, called the ‘Slav Prince’, which, by the way, I am convinced is a portrait of himself; anyone who has had the idea suggested cannot doubt it for a moment; it is Rembrandt's own face without question. The reproductions I have seen of this picture, and, in fact, of all Rembrandt's works, are so poor and so unsatisfactory that I was determined, after my visit to St. Petersburg, to devise a means by which facsimile reproductions in colour of Rembrandt's pictures could be set before the public. The black and white reproductions and the photographs I put on one side at once, because of the impossibility of suggesting colour thereby.

Rembrandt has been reproduced in photograph and photogravure, and by every mechanical process imaginable, but all such reproductions are not only disappointing, but wrong. The light and shade have never been given their true value, and as for colour, it has scarcely been attempted.

After many years of careful thought and consideration as to the best, or the only possible, manner of giving to those who love the master a work which should really be a genuine reproduction of his pictures, I have adapted and developed the modern process of color printing, so as to bring it into sympathy with the subject.

Answers

Passage -1	Para 1	Early doctors were more independent artists than scientists.
	Para 2	Team work is important in medicine now.
	Para 3	Good players don't make good teams.
	Para 4	Over specialization means no one can see the big picture – data can help all of us see that.
	Para 5	The surgery improvement team looked at industries like aviation to learn how to better manage risks.
	Para 6	Simple stuff like checklists helped reduce mortality rate by 50% in surgeries!
Passage-2	Para 1	Your personal life and professional life do mix. Beware when this mixing is online.
	Para 2	The oldies have caught up to FB – they are checking your posts before they hire you.
	Para 3	And even your professors.. OMG, what is the world coming to ☺
	Para 4	Be cautious about what you post – and ideally allow only specified people to see your posts.
Passage-3	Topic	The exploits of the English and French pirates
	Para 1	To state that even though new articles keep coming out about the activities of these pirates, the source of most of these articles is the same, so in essence the information that the reader is receiving is from a very limited perspective.
	Para 2	To explain why the life of the pirates needs to be looked at from a different point of view as well.
	Para 3	To explain the objective of his research.
Passage -4	Topic	Role of the Monetary Policy
	Para 1	to introduce the monetary policy and state that the banking sector is an important component of the same
	Para 2 Para 3	to describe why the banking sector is important and how the failure of the same can lead to a depression-like scenario
	Para 4	to concludes that policymakers haven't learnt from experience and that politics takes precedence over policy
Passage -5	Topic	Rembrandt's works
	Para 1	To state that the colour reproductions, of Rembrandt's works, are of extremely poor quality
	Para 2	To provide some specifics, as to what exactly is wrong, with reproductions of Rembrandt's works
	Para 3	To provide his solution to the problem of accurately reproducing Rembrandt's colour works